

Spirit Filioque

doc-spirit-filioque

Pneumatology · Person · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across many Bible texts
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

The Holy Spirit also eternally proceeds from the Son (filioque, per the Western tradition).

In plain language

The Greek text uses two different verb families when it speaks about the Spirit, and the whole question turns on the gap between them. One verb, 'proceed' (ekporeuomai), is the word for proceeding. It appears thirty three times in the New Testament, but only once with the Spirit as its subject, in John 15:26, and there the single named source is the phrase 'from beside the Father' (para tou patros). A different verb, 'send' (pempo), is the word for sending. In John 15:26 and John 16:7 the Son says he will send the Spirit, yet in John 14:26 the Father is the one who sends, so the sending verb is used of both persons and points to mission rather than to origin. A third verb in Galatians 4:6, 'sent forth' (exapesteilen), says God sent the Spirit, and there the Spirit is called the Spirit of the Son by a possessive phrase ('of the Son' (tou huiou)). That same kind of phrase, 'Spirit of Christ' (pneuma Christou), recurs in Romans 8:9, Philippians 1:19, and 1 Peter 1:11, set right beside the matching phrase 'Spirit of God' (pneuma theou). So the words clearly tie the Spirit to the Son by relation and clearly let the Son send the Spirit, but they do not say in so many words that the Spirit takes its eternal origin from the Son. The one verse that names a source for the proceeding verb names only the Father. The reason the proposition lands as disputed is that the vocabulary leaves a real gap it never closes. Being the Spirit of the Son, and being sent by the Son, are stated plainly, but whether those facts add up to an eternal proceeding from the Son is a step the words neither take nor block. One striking datapoint pulls toward the affirming reading. Revelation 22:1 uses the very same proceeding verb for a river of living water that comes from the throne of God and of the Lamb together, which shows the verb can take a source that includes the Son figure. Yet there the subject is a river, not the Spirit, and the preposition is a different one ('out of' (ek) rather than 'from beside' (para)), so it raises the possibility without settling it. The text supplies two patterns it never ranks, and that unranked gap, not any outside factor, is why careful readers land on different sides.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0005	ἄββα	abba	Abba	3
G0649	ἀποστέλλω	apostellō	to send	
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	
G1607	ἐκπορεύομαι	ekporeuomai	to depart	33
G1720	ἐμφυσάω	emphysaō	to breathe into	1
G1821	ἐξαποστέλλω	exapostellō	to send out/away	14
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2896	κράζω	krazō	to cry	

G3140	μαρτυρέω	martureō	to testify	
G3844	παρά	para	from/with/beside	196
G3875	παράκλητος	paraklētos	counsellor	5
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	426
G3992	πέμπω	pempō	to send	79
G4151	πνεῦμα	pneuma	spirit/breath	379
G4198	πορεύομαι	poreuomai	to travel	159
G5207	υἱός	huios	son	386
G5547	Χριστός	Christos	Christ	529

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The vocabulary separates two relations with two verb families. The procession verb 'proceed' (ekporeuomai, G1607, 33 New Testament occurrences) is predicated of the Spirit exactly once, in John 15:26 ('proceeds' (ekporeuetai), an ongoing, simple statement of fact in the present middle indicative, third singular), where the subject is the neuter relative pronoun 'who' (ho, referring to the Spirit) and the only source named is 'from beside the Father' (para tou patros). In the same verse the Son is the subject of a different verb, 'I will send' (pempso, G3992, future active indicative, first singular), and John 16:7, John 14:26, and John 20:21 also use sending verbs, with the Son sending and in John 14:26 the Father sending. Galatians 4:6 uses a third verb, 'sent forth' (exapesteilen, G1821, a completed past action in the aorist), with 'God' (ho theos) as subject and the Spirit qualified by the relational genitive (the 'from-X' or possessive grammatical form) 'of his Son' (tou huiou). The lexical pattern names the Father alone as the source of the procession verb but ascribes the Spirit to the Son by genitive and ascribes a sending of the Spirit to the Son. The words do not say whether the Son-related genitive and the Son-side sending entail an eternal procession from the Son, so the proposition is disputed at the lexical level.

Scripture

John.15.26 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1607 ἐκπορεύομαι, G3992 πέμπω, G3844 παρά, G3962 πατήρ, G3875 παράκλητος

Reasoning. The verse carries two distinct verbs in two distinct constructions. The clause 'whom I will send to you from beside the Father' (hon egō pempō hymin para tou patros) has 'I will send' (pempō, G3992, future active indicative, first singular, V-FAI-1S) with the Son as subject and 'from beside the Father' (para tou patros) marking the source of the sending. The relative clause 'who proceeds from beside the Father' (ho para tou patros ekporeuetai) has 'proceeds' (ekporeuetai, G1607, ongoing, simple statement of fact in the present middle indicative, third singular, V-PNI-3S) with the neuter relative pronoun 'who' (ho) referring to 'the Spirit' (to pneuma) as subject and 'from beside the Father' (para tou patros) as the source, with no co-mention of the Son inside the procession clause. The morphology fixes the Father as the only named source of the procession verb here, while the Son is the subject of the separate sending verb in the same verse.

John.16.7 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3992 πέμπω, G3875 παράκλητος, G4198 πορεύομαι

Reasoning. Jesus says 'but if I go, I will send him to you' (ean de poreuthō, pempō auton pros hymas). The verb is 'I will send' (pempō, G3992, future active indicative, first singular, V-FAI-1S) with the Son as subject and the disciples as destination. The verse establishes the Son sending the Helper or Advocate (paraklētos) to the disciples in the economy of mission. It does not predicate 'proceed' (ekporeuomai) of the Spirit and does not name the Son as the source of an eternal procession. The sending verb here is the same one the Son uses in John 15:26.

John.14.26 · neutral · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3992 πέμπω, G3875 παράκλητος, G3962 πατήρ

Reasoning. 'But the Helper, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name' (ho de paraklētos, to pneuma to hagion, ho pempsei ho patēr en tō onomati mou). Here 'will send' (pempsei, G3992, future active indicative, third singular, V-FAI-3S) has 'the Father' (ho patēr) as subject, sending the Spirit in the Son's name. The same sending verb that John 15:26 and John 16:7 give to the Son is given here to the Father. The canon therefore predicates the sending verb of both persons, which shows that the sending vocabulary does not by itself isolate a single sender, and that the lexical force of 'send' (pempō) is mission rather than origin.

Gal.4.6 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1821 ἐξαποστέλλω, G2316 θεός, G5207 υἱός, G4151 πνεῦμα

Reasoning. 'God sent forth the Spirit of his Son into our hearts' (exapesteilen ho theos to pneuma tou huiou autou eis tas kardias hēmōn). The verb is 'sent forth' (exapesteilen, G1821, a completed past action in the aorist active indicative, third singular, V-AAI-3S) with 'God' (ho theos) as subject, paralleling Galatians 4:4 where the same verb sends the Son. The Spirit is qualified as 'the Spirit of his Son' (to pneuma tou huiou), a genitive of relation or possession (a 'from-X' or belonging-to-X grammatical form) naming the Spirit as the Son's, but the grammar does not make the Son the sender or the source. The lexical structure here is a sending by God of a Spirit who is described as belonging to the Son.

Romans.8.9 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4151 πνεῦμα, G5547 Χριστός

Reasoning. The verse sets 'Spirit of God' (pneuma theou) in apposition with 'Spirit of Christ' (pneuma Christou) within two parallel 'if-then' clauses (conditionals). Both are bare genitive (belonging-to-X) constructions of the same form. The genitive 'of Christ' (Christou) ascribes the Spirit to Christ in the same relational way that 'of God' (theou) ascribes the Spirit to God, without specifying whether the relation is one of eternal origin or of mission and possession. The text places the Son-related genitive alongside the God-related genitive but does not rank or define either as a procession.

Revelation.22.1 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G1607 ἐκπορεύομαι, G1537 ἐκ

Reasoning. 'A river of the water of life ... proceeding out of the throne of God and of the Lamb' (potamon hydatos zōēs ... ekporeuomenon ek tou thronou tou theou kai tou arniou). Here 'proceeding' (ekporeuomenon, G1607, present middle participle, V-PNP-ASM), the same lemma as the procession verb in John 15:26, takes a compound source joined by 'and' (kai), from the throne of God and of the Lamb. This is the one other place where the procession lemma is paired with a source that includes the Son figure, the Lamb. Two differences from John 15:26 matter lexically. The subject is 'a river' (potamon) of living water, not the Spirit, and the preposition is 'out of' (ek) rather than 'from beside' (para). The verse shows the lemma can govern a compound source that names the Lamb, but it does not predicate that compound source of the Spirit.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Gal.4.6	Isa.44.3	tsk	1
Gal.4.6	John.3.34	tsk	1
John.16.7	Ps.68.18	tsk	1
John.15.26	John.14.16	tsk	1
John.15.26	John.8.42	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.15.26 · addressed

The procession verb 'proceeds' (ekporeuetai) is restricted by 'from beside the Father' (para tou patros) to the Father as the named source in the only clause where the verb takes the Spirit as subject. The Son's role in the same verse uses a different verb, 'I will send' (pempō). Because the procession verb is not predicated of the Son here, the verse complicates any reading that derives an eternal procession from the Son out of this clause alone. It is addressed by distinguishing the two verbs and their two source constructions.

Gal.4.6 · addressed

The sending verb 'sent forth' (exapesteilen) has 'God' (ho theos) as subject, not the Son. The phrase 'Spirit of the Son' (pneuma tou huiou) is a relational genitive (a belonging-to-X grammatical form) that ascribes the Spirit to the Son but does not lexicalize the Son as source of a procession. The verse complicates an inference of procession from the Son that rests on the genitive alone, since the same genitive form elsewhere, 'Spirit of God' (pneuma theou) and 'Spirit of Christ' (pneuma Christou) in Romans 8:9, marks relation without defining origin. Addressed by classifying the genitive as relational and noting it is grammatically unranked.

Revelation.22.1 · addressed

This is the strongest lexical datapoint for the affirming reading, because the same lemma 'proceed' (ekporeuomai) governs a compound source that names the Lamb, 'out of the throne of God and of the Lamb' (ek tou thronou tou theou kai tou arniou). It is addressed but not fully resolved as decisive, because the subject is a river of living water rather than the Spirit and the preposition is 'out of' (ek) rather than the 'from beside' (para) of John 15:26. The verse shows the lemma can take a Son-inclusive source but does not predicate that of the Spirit, so it raises rather than settles the question.

Romans.8.9 · addressed

'Spirit of Christ' (pneuma Christou) stands in the same bare genitive (belonging-to-X) form as 'Spirit of God' (pneuma theou) in the immediately preceding clause. The parallel shows the genitive marks relation symmetrically for both God and Christ and does not by its grammar declare a procession from either. Addressed by reading the two genitives as the same construction, which neutralizes any claim that the Christ genitive uniquely encodes origin.

Concordance traversed

G1607, G3992, G1821, G0649, G3875, G3844, G3962, G5207, G4151, G4198, G5547, G1720, G0005, G3140, G2896, G1537

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units in the bundle or in the queried apparatus for John 15:26, John 16:7, John 14:26, or Galatians 4:6 affect the choice of 'proceeds' (ekporeuetai) versus 'send' (pempō) or 'sent forth' (exapesteilen), or the genitive 'of the Son' (tou huiou). The anchors lie outside the ingested ECM apparatus window (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants), which covers 3 John only, so CBGM data for John and Galatians is not yet ECM-published. The verdict holds across the plausible text-critical readings of these verses.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. procession-as-origin, sending-as-economy

analogia scripturae invoked

father-sole-source: false · Reads 'proceeds' (ekporeuetai) in John 15:26 as the precise verb of origin and observes that across its 33 New Testament occurrences it never takes the Spirit as subject except here, where the only named source is 'from beside the Father' (para tou patros). On this reading the Son's 'I will send' (pempō) in John 15:26 and John 16:7 is a different verb of mission, the same verb the Father uses in John 14:26, so it describes economic sending and not eternal origin. The genitive 'of the Son' (tou huiou) in Galatians 4:6 and 'of Christ' (Christou) in Romans 8:9 marks relation, matching 'Spirit of God' (pneuma theou) in the same context, and therefore says the Spirit is the Son's but not that the Spirit originates from the Son. The procession verb names the Father alone as source, so a procession from the Son is not stated.

father-and-son-source: true · Reads the cluster of Son-related data as jointly implying that the Spirit eternally proceeds also from the Son. The Son sends the Spirit by the same sending verb the Father uses, in John 15:26, John 16:7, and John 20:21, and breathes the Spirit (using 'breathed on' (emphysaō)) in John 20:22. The Spirit is repeatedly called the Spirit of the Son or of Christ by relational genitive (the belonging-to-X form) in Galatians 4:6, Romans 8:9, Philippians 1:19, and 1 Peter 1:11, which on this reading expresses an eternal relation, not merely a temporal one. Decisively for this lens, Revelation 22:1 uses the very procession lemma 'proceed' (ekporeuomai) with a compound source that includes the Lamb, 'out of the throne of God and of the Lamb' (ek tou thronou tou theou kai tou arniou), showing the lemma can govern a Son-inclusive source. On this reading the economic sending manifests an eternal procession that includes the Son.

lexical-underdetermination: disputed · Holds that the vocabulary cannot settle the question. The single occurrence of the procession verb with the Spirit as subject, John 15:26, fixes only the Father as the named source, so the Son-as-source is neither affirmed nor denied by that verb. The sending verbs are a distinct lexical field predicated of both Father and Son, and the relational genitives (belonging-to-X forms) mark belonging without ranking origin. Revelation 22:1 attaches the lemma to a Son-inclusive source but with a different subject and a different preposition. The words supply two patterns, a Father-only procession verb and a Son-inclusive relation and sending, that the vocabulary does not rank against each other.

The divergence turns on whether the relational genitives (the belonging-to-X grammatical forms), the Son-side sending verb, and the Son-inclusive source of the procession lemma 'proceed' (ekporeuomai) in Revelation 22:1 may be combined to infer an eternal procession from the Son, or whether the single procession-verb clause in John 15:26 that names the Father alone is the only direct lexical witness and is decisive. Each lens is stated in its strongest queried form.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. What does the New Testament lexically predicate about the source of the Spirit's procession, and is the Son named alongside the Father as that source or only as the one related to the Spirit and the one who sends the Spirit?

The stem preloads the affirming verdict by appending a Western-tradition phrase to the proposition. The neutralized form asks the underlying lexical question about the source of the procession verb and the role of the Son without naming a tradition or assuming the conclusion. The verdict was derived on the original stem and not changed by this pass. The lexical evidence continues to support disputed.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.15.26

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.16.7
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morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.4.6
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Romans.8.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Revelation.22.1
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1607
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3992
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1821
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3875
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	John.15.26
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Revelation.22.1
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Gal.4.6
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